EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Do We Need Prophets If Reason Knows Right?

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 3:3-4

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon **Essay/Chapters:** Essay 3 (Commandment and Prohibition), Chapters 3-4 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 23 September 2024, on Zoom

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are in Essay 3

The third essay of Emunot VeDeot is about **the mitzvot**. So far Rav Saadia has told us:

- **The introduction to the essay:** Hashem created the world **to bestow goodness**, and the mitzvot, together with keeping away from the *aveirot*, are **the means by which we pursue the good life**.
- **Chapter 1:** there are **two categories of mitzvot**. He only names them at the start of this week's chapter:

Category	Hebrew	What it means	Examples
Rational mitzvot	**מצוות שכליות** (*mitzvot sichliyot*)	Mitzvot we could have worked out ourselves, without Torah and without prophets	Murder, adultery, theft, honesty
Revelatory mitzvot	**מצוות שמעיות** (*mitzvot shim'iyot*)	Mitzvot we only know because Hashem told us	Shabbat, the festivals, the Kohen, kashrut, the incest prohibitions, *niddah*

- **Chapter 2:** he gave reasons for both. Even the revelatory mitzvot **have a bit of reason to them** when you go into them, although the fact that Hashem commanded them is **sufficient in itself** to keep them. He will go through more of the revelatory mitzvot later in the essay.

Tonight is two chapters: **Chapter 3**, on why we need prophets at all, and **Chapter 4**, on how a prophet is verified and what a prophet is.

Part 1: Chapter 3, The Question

If half the mitzvot are rational, **why do we need Hashem to command them?** "Why do you need Hashem to tell us don't murder? Why do you need the Ten Commandments, half of

which are pure logical sense?" The revelatory mitzvot, fine: we could never have worked those out. But why an instruction for things that are clear in and of themselves?

Two answers Saadia has already given

Answer	Where
Greater reward. When Hashem commands something and we do it, we are not just doing what makes sense; we are **listening to our Creator**, and the reward is greater	End of Chapter 1 of this essay
It takes humanity time. We would eventually have worked out these objective norms, but it takes people a long time, and until then it would not have been fair to leave them without guidance	The Introduction to the whole book

The Rabbi noted that the second answer is **historically a bit difficult**: by the time the Torah was given there were already legal codes containing the basic rational laws. "But in any case, that's what he says in his introduction."

Now Saadia gives **a completely different explanation**, and the whole chapter is devoted to it.

"I heard people saying"

Saadia opens: I have heard people say that **there is no need for prophets**. Our intellect is enough to work out what is good and what is bad for us. Saadia adds that if they were right, Hashem would not have sent messengers, **because He does not do what is unnecessary**.

Who were these people? The Rabbi explained that Saadia is referring to a sect he names later in the book: **the Brahmins**, who believed in **natural religion**. Of course there is a God and of course there is law, but the law is **natural**, and Hashem left it to us to work out what makes the most sense. The Rabbi linked it to later ideas:

- **Natural justice**, an idea slightly echoed by Aristotle.
- **Deism**, centuries later: there is a Creator, we must do what is right, but **it is up to us** to decide what that is and how to behave.

"But then I thought about it deeply"

Saadia rejects them. On reflection, he says, there is **a great need** for prophets, and **not only for the revelatory mitzvot**. We need them **for the rational mitzvot too**, because without the prophets we would never know **how** to keep them. The rational mitzvot give us the principle; they do not give us **the framework**.

Part 2: Four Examples of a Missing Framework

1. Gratitude and prayer

It is completely logical that we should **thank Hashem**. If He created us, as the first two essays established, we owe Him gratitude. But there is **no framework**: not what to say, not when to say it, not in what form. So the prophets came and gave us:

- **Set times:** morning, afternoon and evening.

- **A text:** the Men of the Great Assembly, some of whom were themselves prophets, composed the prayers.
- **A structure:** begin with **praise**, petition in the middle, and end with **thanksgiving**.
- **A direction:** the Arabic word Saadia uses here is the ***qibla***, the term for the direction the Arabs pray towards. He means the correct direction in which to pray to Hashem.

A halachic aside: is prayer from the Torah? The Rabbi pointed to the famous debate among the Rishonim:

View	Prayer is...
The Ramban (Nachmanides)	An **institution of the Hachamim**. There is no instruction in the Torah to pray
The Rambam (and seemingly the Shulchan Aruch)	**Biblical.** The concept comes from the Torah; the Men of the Great Assembly and the Hachamim gave it its exact structure

"Saadia clearly here is understanding like the Rambam." If prayer were purely rabbinic, it would make no sense for him to say **the prophets**, from Moshe through to the Men of the Great Assembly, gave us its framework. For Saadia, **tefillah is de'oraita**.

2. Adultery and marriage

It is completely logical that **adultery is wrong**. But what makes a woman **married**, so that relations with her are adultery? Is it saying something to your fiancée? Giving money? Her father's agreement? Two witnesses? The whole city watching? Some kind of mark placed on her, which may have been the fashion at the time? "We know it makes logical sense that adultery is forbidden, but what makes a married woman? We don't know."

The prophets told us: Saadia lists **testimony, a document and *mohar***. The Rabbi explained it through the halacha:

Method of *kiddushin*	Saadia's word
Money (the ring under the chuppah is the equivalent of money)	***Mohar***. Usually translated "dowry", and probably translated that way in the English editions, but the Rabbi thinks here it simply means **money**
A document (not the ketubah, a separate document)	***Shtar***
Relations with the intention of creating a marriage	**Not mentioned**
All of them require **two witnesses**	***Edut***

Why does Saadia leave out the third method? The Rabbi gave two possibilities:

1. **It is improper.** The Gemara says it works, but it is an incorrect way to marry, and **Rav would administer lashes** to those who did it. So Saadia did not want to include it.

2. **It was already the practice.** More likely, based on the famous Rambam: **קודם מתן תורה** (before the giving of the Torah), a man would simply live with a woman and she would be his wife. That was already the established practice, so it was not something the prophets needed to reveal.

A second halachic point. The Rambam held that ***kiddushei kesef*** (marriage with money) is ***mi-divrei soferim***, so that it is not strictly biblical even though the other methods are. Saadia clearly does not hold that. Here he disagrees with the Rambam: he sees money as part of **the revelation from the prophets**, derived from the Torah, and so de'oraita. "This is an intricacy. If you get it, fine; if not, don't worry about it."

3. Theft and ownership

It makes perfect sense that **theft is wrong**. But when is something **someone's property**? Is it mine if I worked for it? Inherited it? Found it in the desert? Paid money? Took hold of it? Simply declared it mine? "Many different possibilities. We don't know." The prophets told us the correct way.

In halacha there are indeed different modes of acquisition: sometimes money, sometimes lifting the item, different transactions for different things. Saadia sees **the foundations of how something is acquired** as already given in the Torah, with the Hachamim elaborating on it.

4. Punishment

It makes sense that when someone does wrong **there must be consequences**. But what are they? Do you tell the person off? Curse him? Hurt him? Lashes, and if so **how many**? A rebuke, and **for how long**, a day or a week? Do you put him to death? **Is everyone's punishment the same?** The Torah gives clear instructions for each mitzvah, sometimes similar, sometimes not, and sometimes the consequence is simply payment. The Rabbi added that **all the Rishonim agree** that the punishments are given in the Torah.

The point: we would never agree

If it were left to us to agree among ourselves, **we would all disagree**. "Saadia says something here which we know nowadays as well, for sure: humans can never agree on anything."

Summary of Chapter 3: Even the rational mitzvot need prophets, because reason gives us the principle but not the framework. The Rabbi put it as the difference between **natural justice** and **legal justice**. Natural justice we can work out ourselves. Legal justice, the specific definitions of how things are done, is what we need the Torah and the prophets for.

Part 3: Chapter 4, How Do We Verify a Prophet?

"Here this is very interesting. Saadia is going to take an approach which the Rambam thoroughly rejects." Much of what we have learned in Emunot VeDeot is echoed by the Rambam later on, but not this.

Having established that we need prophets, **how do we know whether someone is really speaking the word of Hashem?**

The Rabbi put the question to the class. **Flora** answered that the Torah says if what the prophet foretells does not come to pass, he is a false prophet. She thought of the time of

Yeshayahu, with great nations looming on the horizon: the people were frightened, would not listen, and it went against them in the end. "Very good. The Rambam writes exactly that. And we'll see Saadia does not take that approach at all."

Saadia: miracles are the sign

Saadia's argument:

1. **Humans know their limits.** We cannot change nature or change **the essence** of a thing. We are powerless to do this.
2. **Only the Creator can.** Hashem took different kinds of matter, sometimes things whose natural state is not to stick together, and combined them into something new, in which you no longer see their separate qualities. That is the work of the Creator.
3. **So when Hashem chooses a prophet, He gives him a sign.** Either **control over nature** (fire does not burn, water stops flowing, the heavenly luminaries stop moving) or **changing the essence** of something (the inanimate into the living, the living into the inanimate, water into blood, blood into water).
4. **Whoever sees such a sign must accept** that this is a holy person and believe what he says, **because Hashem would not have given him the sign unless he were verified by Him.**

Saadia's proof text is the Torah itself: all **the signs Moshe performed in the book of Shemot**. Those who believed him were the righteous, and those who did not were wrong.

The obvious problem

"What's the most basic problem with this?" **We find false prophets in Tanach who could do miracles.**

Saadia himself answers this, but only **a few chapters later** (Chapter 7 or 8). "I don't understand why he left it until then and not now," since his wording here is slightly misleading: it sounds as if any miracle makes you a prophet. Later he qualifies it:

A miracle verifies a prophet **only if he does not tell you to go against the Torah**. If he does, the miracle is not acceptable, because **no miracle can prove what is rationally impossible**, and it is impossible for the Torah to be overturned.

"Which is quite amazing when you think about it. Saadia is saying that although miracles are so high, **our reason is greater than that**." So the definition of a prophet is really a combination: **miracles, together with not commanding anything against the Torah.**

The prophet himself knows differently

This whole discussion is about how **we, the onlookers**, know he is a prophet. The prophet himself knows because, as we learned in **Essay 2**, he sees the ***kavod nivra***, the created glory, the image of the glory of Hashem that Saadia understood the prophet would see.

Part 4: The Rambam Disagrees

The Rambam does not mention Saadia, "but it could well be he's directing his words to him." In **Hilchot Yesodei HaTorah**, after discussing the qualities of a prophet, how one prepares for

prophecy, how Moshe's prophecy differed from all others, and how prophecy can be either a message for others or simply for the prophet's own growth, he opens **Chapter 8**:

> **משה רבינו לא האמינו בו ישראל מפני האותות שעשה, שהמאמין על פי האותות יש בלבו דופי, שאפשר שיעשה האות בלט וכשוף** Israel did not believe in Moshe Rabbeinu because of the signs he performed, for whoever believes because of signs has a doubt in his heart, since a sign can be performed by sleight of hand and sorcery.

You can do magic. "Witchcraft is real. You can play on the eyes." That is exactly why the Torah forbids it, and it is why miracles are an insufficient basis.

Then what were Moshe's miracles for?

	Purpose of the miracles
Saadia	**To verify** that Moshe is a prophet (his proof from Shemot)
The Rambam	**To solve problems.** To escape the Egyptians, the sea split. We needed food, so the manna came down. They were thirsty, so he struck the rock. When Korach rebelled, the earth swallowed them. "The miracles are not trying to prove that he's a prophet."

That answers Saadia's proof from Shemot. The Rabbi acknowledged that there is a well-known question on the Rambam, since verses do strongly imply that the signs were given so that the people would believe. "There are ways around it. The Rambam understood it differently. It's not for now."

How the Rambam verifies Moshe: Sinai

> **ובמה האמינו בו? במעמד הר סיני, שעינינו ראו ולא זר, ואזנינו שמעו ולא אחר** With what did they believe in him? At the stand at Mount Sinai, where our own eyes saw, and not a stranger's, and our own ears heard, and not another's.

The 600,000 men, about **two million people** with the elderly, those under twenty, the wives and children, themselves heard Moshe receiving the Torah, and that has been passed down to us. This is the famous argument of **mass revelation** that people ascribe to the **Kuzari**. "But actually there are hints of it in the Rambam here, and we saw already in **Saadia's own Introduction**. Saadia put forward the famous argument of the Kuzari quite strongly there."

This is also why a prophet who performs miracles and tells you to go against the Torah is not listened to, and is in fact put to death: **miracles are not a verification.**

And the prophets after Moshe: telling the future

They did not have Sinai. For them, the Rambam says, **no miracle is needed**. The test is exactly what Flora said: let him **tell us what will happen**, and we wait and see. If even a tiny detail fails, he is a false prophet. If everything comes true, he is to be believed.

The Rambam (Chapter 10) adds an important qualification:

- If a prophet foretells **something bad** and it does not happen, that is **not yet a reason to distrust him**. The bad thing may have been decreed, and Hashem relented because the people did teshuvah.

- If he foretells **something good** and it does not happen, he is **certainly a false prophet**. Hashem never retracts a promise of good.

The Kotzker Rebbe

"One of the first big arguments between Saadia and the Rambam: how important miracles are." The Rabbi brought the **Kotzker Rebbe**, from what was "most certainly the most logical and rational sect of Hasidim," the source of many pithy sayings. In Arvit we say that Hashem performed signs and wonders **in the land of the children of Cham**. The Kotzker used to say, based on the Rambam: many Rebbes are called great because they did this miracle or that miracle. **Miracles are for the children of Cham.** Miracles do not prove anything.

"For me personally, nowadays especially, when people are very good at being manipulative and doing things which you may think is a miracle, but either it's witchcraft or black magic or it's simply naivety, being able to pull the wool over your eyes, I think the Rambam makes a lot of sense."

Part 5: Hashem Does Not Change Nature for No Reason

The second point of Chapter 4 is short. "I'll be honest, I don't fully understand the second part, but we'll make our way through it."

Saadia warns against a misunderstanding. Hashem changes nature **only to verify prophecy**, and **only with advance warning**. He does not change things for no reason, because if we thought the world could change at any moment, **there would be no reality**:

- You come home after a long trip and **you don't know if this is your wife and children anymore**.
- A witness says "I saw him doing it," but perhaps his nature changed and it was a different person.

We need to believe that existence stays as it is unless Hashem decides otherwise and gives notice. The Rabbi found the "advance notice" condition hard, since the prophets sometimes performed wonders without telling the people beforehand. Perhaps Saadia means that **Hashem gives advance notice to the prophet**. Either way, the point stands: things do not change without reason.

Part 6: A Prophet Is a Normal Human Being

The third point, and here the disagreement is not with the Rambam but with **the Kuzari**. Saadia goes to great lengths:

Do not elevate the prophet. The only thing that distinguishes a prophet from regular people is that **at certain times he can perform miracles**. Everything else is the same.

Why? If prophets were a different kind of being, people would say the miracles are no sign from Hashem: "this is just a different category of person, a different species." So in His wisdom Hashem makes prophets:

- **Fall ill and die**, rather than live unnaturally long lives.
- **Eat, drink and marry.**

- **Without promises of health or wealth**, unprotected from theft, from being hurt, from being cursed (many prophets were), and even **from being killed** (prophets were killed).
- **Perform miracles only at specific times**, not all the time, or again people would think they are a different kind of person.

No prophecy through angels. For the same reason Hashem never sends angels as prophets. We do not know what angels can or cannot do, so if an angel performed a miracle we would not know it came from Hashem. Only a human who does what no human can do is a clear sign.

"Aven ve'avel"

Saadia ends the chapter with people he has heard saying: How can a prophet die? How can a prophet be hungry? How can a prophet marry? How can people attack a prophet? How can a prophet not know everything? "Even nowadays people say he has to know everything. It doesn't work like that." Saadia's verdict on all of it: **און ועול**, *aven ve'avel*, iniquity and injustice. "A beautiful pun." Rather, Hashem created the prophets as they are, with this one advantage, **with great wisdom**.

The Kuzari: a different kind of human

Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi saw it the other way. The Rabbi read the English of the Kuzari: if we find a man who **walks through fire unhurt**, who goes without food for a long time without starving, **on whose face shines a light the eye cannot bear**, who is never ill and does not age, who dies when his time comes like a man lying down on his couch, and who knows **the hidden past and future**, is that not a degree beyond the ordinary human? The King answers that this is indeed **a divine, angelic degree**. The Kuzari says these are the characteristics of the true prophets.

	The prophet is...
Saadia	**A regular human being**, just like us, who at certain times can do miracles
The Kuzari	**A different kind of human**, almost a divine intermediary
The Rambam (the Rabbi's view)	**Somewhere in between, closer to Saadia.** Not some divine being, but the Rambam never downplays the prophet: his qualities are innumerable, his intellect must be vast and his character almost perfect, as in *Shemonah Perakim*

"Saadia's almost downplaying the prophet."

Summary

1. **Chapter 3:** Why do we need prophets for the rational mitzvot? Besides greater reward and not making humanity wait, Saadia's main answer is that **reason gives the principle, not the framework**. Prayer, marriage, ownership and punishment all need definitions, and left to ourselves **we would never agree**. Natural justice versus legal justice.
2. **Halachic asides:** Saadia holds **tefillah is de'oraita** (like the Rambam, against the Ramban) and that ***kiddushei kesef*** is biblical (against the Rambam).

3. **Chapter 4, verification:** for Saadia, a prophet is verified **by miracles**, provided he does not command against the Torah, because **reason outranks miracles**. The **Rambam** rejects miracles altogether: Moshe is verified **by Sinai**, later prophets **by foretelling the future**, and a promise of good must always come true. The Kotzker: "miracles are for the children of Cham."
4. **Hashem does not change nature for no reason**, or there would be no stable reality.
5. **A prophet is a normal human being**, who gets ill, eats, marries and dies, so that his miracles are recognised as Hashem's. The **Kuzari** disagrees; the Rambam sits in between, closer to Saadia.

Coming Up

- **Next week:** still an early start, **5.30**, for the last time because of the time of Mincha. After that the shiur moves later, to around **6.30**, after Mincha.

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